FREE GUIDE · 2026 EDITION

How to Run a Growing Substack for $0 a Month

The 16 free tools every new Substack writer needs, grouped by job, with free-plan limits and one practical tip each.

StackKit · stackkit.ink

Start here

Hi, and welcome! When you start a Substack, it's tempting to sign up for every shiny tool. You don't need to. You need a few good free ones that each do one job well, so you can spend your time writing.

That's this guide: 16 tools researched using official product and help pages, all with a useful free option or no monthly platform fee. For each one you'll get what it does, what the free plan actually includes, and one tip you can use today.

1. **Writing & editing** · Grammarly, Hemingway Editor, LanguageTool
2. **Images & design** · Canva, Unsplash, remove.bg
3. **Scheduling & planning** · Notion, Typefully, Buffer
4. **Links & analytics** · Google Search Console, Bitly, Linktree
5. **Growth** · SparkLoop, Tally
6. **Monetization** · Ko-fi, Gumroad

How to use this: don't set up all 16 at once. Pick one tool from each section this week, use it on your next post, and come back for the rest. Each card links to its StackKit directory page. Confirm current terms on the official site before signing up.

Official free-plan information researched Nov 5, 2026 (CST). Plans can change. This is research, not a hands-on test. $0 a month means no recurring tool subscription within the listed limits; sales, payment-processing and referral fees may apply. Paid Substack subscriptions also incur fees. Always confirm on the vendor's site. StackKit is independent and not affiliated with Substack Inc.

01 Writing & editing

Clean drafts without hiring an editor.

Grammarly

stackkit.ink/tools/grammarly

Spelling, grammar and tone checks in your browser, including the Substack editor.

Free plan: Free: spelling and grammar checks, tone detection and 100 AI prompts per month. Advanced rewriting and plagiarism checks require a paid plan.

Tip: Install the browser extension and do one final pass inside the Substack editor right before you hit publish, since that's where last-minute typos sneak in.

Hemingway Editor

stackkit.ink/tools/hemingway-editor

Highlights long, dense sentences, passive voice and adverbs so posts read faster.

Free plan: Free web editor: readability scoring and highlighted writing issues. AI rewrites and advanced grammar fixes belong to the paid Editor Plus, not the free editor.

Tip: Paste in your intro and look at the hardest-to-read sentences. Simplify where it helps, but keep your own voice.

LanguageTool

stackkit.ink/tools/languagetool

Grammar and style checker that works in 30+ languages.

Free plan: Free Basic: up to 2,000 characters per text field and 3 AI rephrasings per day. Advanced checks require Premium.

Tip: Great if you write in more than one language, or as a second opinion next to Grammarly. Check a post section by section to stay under the character cap.

02 Images & design

Headers and social cards that look like you meant it.

Canva

stackkit.ink/tools/canva

Drag-and-drop design for post headers, social cards and logos.

Free plan: Free editor, free templates and free design elements; 5 GB cloud storage. Pro content is watermarked unless separately licensed or used with a paid plan.

Tip: Make one header template in your brand colors and duplicate it for every post. Consistent headers make your archive look like a real publication.

Unsplash

stackkit.ink/tools/unsplash

Huge library of high-quality free photos.

Free plan: Images under the Unsplash License are free for commercial and non-commercial use, with no required attribution. Unsplash+ content has a separate paid license. Do not resell unmodified photos.

Tip: Credit the photographer in the caption anyway. It's polite, and Substack captions are an easy place to do it.

remove.bg

stackkit.ink/tools/remove-bg

Removes image backgrounds in one click.

Free plan: Free low-resolution previews up to 0.25 megapixels. Full-resolution downloads generally require paid credits; one sign-up credit is a one-time extra, not an ongoing free allowance.

Tip: Use the free preview for a small cut-out in a header. Check that it stays sharp at the size you will publish.

03 Scheduling & planning

Know what you're publishing next week.

Notion

stackkit.ink/tools/notion

All-in-one notes, docs and databases: perfect for an editorial calendar.

Free plan: Free for solo use: unlimited pages and blocks, 5 MB per uploaded file, 7-day page history and 10 guests. Multi-member workspaces have a block limit; Notion AI is only a trial.

Tip: Make one database with columns for Idea, Draft, Scheduled and Published, plus a date. Drop every idea in the moment you have it.

Typefully

stackkit.ink/tools/typefully

Writing-first scheduler for X, LinkedIn, Threads, Bluesky and Substack Notes.

Free plan: The official Notes announcement confirms free Substack Notes scheduling. Free-plan posting allowances apply; check current pricing before planning a posting cadence.

Tip: Draft a few Notes from your next newsletter and schedule within your account's free allowance. Notes scheduling is not long-form newsletter scheduling.

Buffer

stackkit.ink/tools/buffer

Simple social scheduling across many networks.

Free plan: Free: up to 3 channels, 10 scheduled posts per channel at a time, and 1 user. Slots refill when posts publish; it is not a 10-post monthly cap.

Tip: Use it to share each new post to the channels Typefully doesn't cover, like Instagram or Facebook.

04 Links & analytics

See what's working.

Google Search Console

stackkit.ink/tools/google-search-console

Shows which Google searches bring readers to your posts.

Free plan: Free service. Requires ownership verification of your website; available verification methods depend on the site or platform.

Tip: Start only if you can verify ownership using your publication settings or domain DNS. A custom domain may cost money separately; do not buy one just for this guide.

Bitly

stackkit.ink/tools/bitly

Short links and QR codes for sharing your newsletter; detailed reporting is paid.

Free plan: Free with ads: 5 links and 2 QR codes per month. Historical click and scan reporting requires a paid plan.

Tip: Use a free QR code for a handout linking to your subscribe page. Test the destination and any ad experience before printing.

Linktree

stackkit.ink/tools/linktree

One link-in-bio page with all your links.

Free plan: Free: unlimited links, core appearance options and basic analytics. Advanced analytics and extra customization require paid tiers.

Tip: Put your subscribe link first and your best introductory post second, so visitors can choose an easy next step.

05 Growth

Learn what readers need; explore recommendations.

SparkLoop

stackkit.ink/tools/sparkloop

Earn referral fees by recommending other newsletters through the Partner Network.

Free plan: Partner Network: no fixed fee; application and approval required. It deducts 20% commission plus 3.5% fees from earnings. Buying recommendations is a separate paid service.

Tip: This earns from recommending other newsletters, not free subscriber acquisition. SparkLoop recommends waiting until 500–1,000 subscribers; save it for later if you are just starting.

Tally

stackkit.ink/tools/tally

Free, flexible forms: reader surveys, feedback, submissions.

Free plan: Free: unlimited forms and submissions within fair-use guidelines; file uploads up to 10 MB each. Removing Tally branding and custom domains require Pro.

Tip: Send new subscribers a 2-question survey: 'What do you want more of?' and 'What do you do?' Write the next posts from the answers.

06 Monetization

Earn before (or alongside) paid subscriptions.

Ko-fi

stackkit.ink/tools/ko-fi

Tip jar, memberships and a small shop.

Free plan: No monthly fee. Default Standard charges 5% on payments. Ko-fi Free has 0% on tips, 5% on memberships, shop sales and commissions. Payment-processor fees also apply.

Tip: Before sharing your tip link, check whether your account uses Standard or Ko-fi Free. Add the link only where it feels useful, such as a post readers often return to.

Gumroad

stackkit.ink/tools/gumroad

Sell digital products: guides, templates, presets.

Free plan: No monthly fee: 10% + $0.50 per direct/profile sale; 30% on Discover sales. Selling is not fee-free.

Tip: Try a small checklist or template based on a topic you already cover. Review the transaction fees before setting a price.

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